

Monticello-University of Virginia
Archaeological Field School 2025

Review: Weeks 3 and 4

1. Make sure you understand the following concepts, the models in which they are imbedded, and the ways in which they figure Monticello research. How are these ideas essential to advancing our understanding of past dynamics, based on archaeological evidence?

Geoarchaeology

- Soil vs. sediment
- Alluvium vs. colluvium
- Residual vs. transported parent material
- Grain size: Cobbles, Pebbles, Sand, Silt, Clay
- Soil profiles and their horizons
- Gleyed soil

Paleoethnobotany

- Pollen
- Phytoliths
- Macrobotanicals
- Flotation
- Pollen diagram

Archaeological spatial structure

- "Site structure"
- Special vs. general activity areas
- Artifact size sorting

Intra-site artifact distributions: data recovery and visualization

- Interpolation
- Spatial autocorrelation
- Variogram
- Inverse distance weighing
- Kriging

Dendrochronology

- Causes of tree-ring width variation
- Ecological succession

2. Some questions

What have we learned about the historical ecology of Monticello Mountain from our analysis of sediments deposited in the Paw Paw Valley? Sketch the links from the physical evidence to interpretation.

Describe and interpret the layers we saw in the Rivanna River cut bank at Monasukapanough. What were the depositional and pedogenic processes responsible for the layers we saw?

How might our fields observations and interpretations at Monosukapanough relate to the pollen, phytolith, chemical, stratigraphic, and dating evidence from the Paw Paw Valley covered in the “Monticello Geoarchaeology” lecture?

Pick a quadrat that you recently excavated. Describe the contexts you excavated and layers you saw in the profile. What is our current understanding of the processes that created the layers?

Describe the similarities and differences between the layers you saw in the quadrat profiles at Coan Hall and those on the East Lawn that we have excavated to subsoil. What are the causes of the similarities and differences?

Describe the taphonomic processes that affect the preservation of macrobotanical remains.

What can macrobotanical remains tell us about the people who lived at a site? Examples?

Describe how we are using evidence from the following sources to make inferences about social inequality at Site 8 and 6.

- Distribution maps of individual ware types.

- Distribution maps of artifact size.

- Distribution of subfloor pits at Site 8.

Describe how we are using evidence from dendrochronology to unravel the forest history of Monticello Mountain and its agricultural and ornamental landscapes.

3. Artifacts:

Ceramic identification:

- Material (i.e., coarse earthenware, etc.)

- Ware Type (creamware, etc.)

- Decoration (painted, printed, etc.)

Ceramic ware-type manufacturing date ranges.

For other artifact classes, identify: material, morphological features (parts), manufacturing technique:

Pipes

Vessel Glass

Nails